

## Chapter 4: The Harmonic Entrepreneur

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### Abstract

Shane and Venkataraman (2000) define entrepreneurship as the study of how, by whom, and with what effects opportunities are discovered, evaluated, and exploited. Stemming on this approach, it is necessary to place the lens on the entrepreneurial process and on the way individuals act and make strategic decisions (Baron & Shane, 2007; Moroz & Hindle, 2012; Bennett & Chatterji, 2023). Entrepreneurship (Shane, 2000, 2003; Shane & Venkataraman, 2000; Krueger et al., 2000; Eckhardt & Shane, 2003; Audretsch, 2012), in fact, arises from the encounter between opportunities and enterprising individuals; it is not enough for an opportunity to exist, but it is necessary that someone must recognize it, evaluate it, and decide to act. The today's context of epochal change calls for a paradigm that overcome a static vision of entrepreneurial traits, bringing together the individual and their relationships, the firm and its ecosystems, the need to innovate and the resulting social and environmental effects (European Commission, 2021).

Stemming from this background that is based on a double nexus (individual–opportunity and individual–context) (Dimov, 2002; Shane and Eckhardt, 2003; Fortunato, 2011; Sarason et al., 2016; Brown et al., 2024), the present chapter introduces a new perspective that frames entrepreneurs as agents of multi-level change, not only in their organizations and contexts but also in their own selves (Wiklund et al., 2017; Denicolai et al., 2015; Kuratko et al., 2015; Munoz & Dimov, 2023). These agents are in individual not separate from opportunities and context (Sarason et al., 2006), therefore, across the entrepreneurial process (Shane & Venkataraman, 2000), they can co-evolve. In this perspective, this chapter examines how Harmonic Entrepreneurs generate value in a way that is consistent with both who they are and the context in which they operate, by integrating personal attributes, experience, actions, environmental conditions, and strategic choices within a multidimensional perspective (Wiklund et al., 2017; Ranfagni & Runfola, 2018; De Cuyper et al., 2024; Passarelli, 2024). The harmonic entrepreneur could be represented as the new leader needed in today's world, who integrates ethical values, innovation, and sustainability into entrepreneurship.

### 4.1 The genesis of the concept of Harmonic Entrepreneur (HE)

In a very complex economic and social world, the idea of the Harmonic Entrepreneur responds to the urgent challenge for entrepreneurs to connect *who* they are (identity and value) with *what* and *how* they do (decisions, actions, relationships) (Steyaert, 2007; Gregori, 2024). Classical economic

thought paid limited and often indirect attention to the nature of the entrepreneur. Ricardo (1817) almost ignored the role, while Smith (1776) merged entrepreneur, capitalist, and manager into a single role, driven by self-interest and coordinated by the “invisible hand”. Cantillon (1756) offers the first definition of “entrepreneur” as a key figure in economic self-regulation, someone who bears risk, competes, and adjusts to market signals, laid the foundation for modern economic models. Cantillon’s entrepreneur was not merely a government contractor but a market agent whose role was essential for the proper functioning of the economy. This self-regulating role of entrepreneurs mirrors Isaac Newton’s concept of gravity regulating the physical world, and Cantillon’s work can be seen as applying similar principles to the economy. Say (1861) separated the capitalist/owner from the entrepreneur, who organizes, directs, and combines resources creatively. Marshall in his *Principles of Economics* (1890) held land, labor, capital, and organization as the four factors of production, and considered entrepreneurship as the driving factor that brings these four factors together. Overall, the classical tradition portrayed the entrepreneur/capitalist as a *homo faber/homo economicus*, guided primarily by instrumental rationality and profit maximization. However, the classical approach is partial, in fact, it ignores other dimensions that inform entrepreneurial choice. The role of the Austrian school, the entrepreneur took on a totally dynamic and central attractive role in economic development. Schumpeter (1934) (Austrian School) in fact developed a theory in which the defining function of the entrepreneur is innovation: “*doing new things or doing old things in a new way*”; this new lens interprets the entrepreneur as a creative force who introduces new combinations of resources, generating “creative destruction” that breaks the existing equilibrium and generates development. In this perspective, the aim is not only profit, but also the transformation of the economic system and the creation of new value. In 1973 Kirzner’s *Competition and Entrepreneurship* (Neo-Austrian School) introduce the concept of alertness, that reinforce the “proactive” attitude of entrepreneurship, defining the entrepreneur as an intermediary who discovers and exploits market opportunities. According to Kirzner (2009), in fact, is always possible to say that by “seeing” the opportunity, the entrepreneur actually creates it. Drucker (1985) offers a new perspective, by explicitly rejecting the cognitive and psychological approach to entrepreneurship that characterizes the (neo-)Austrian school, Drucker (1985) argues that “*the entrepreneur always seeks change, responds to it, and exploits it as an opportunity*”, by giving to the entrepreneur the function to introduce or do new things in a new way. This definition represents a crucial point, since it preserves the centrality of change and opportunity-seeking but transforms entrepreneurship from a discovery function driven by alertness (Kirzner) into a strategic vision that translate the idea into practice and results.

However, the literature proposes also a broader vision that can combine different individual characteristics with the entrepreneurial role (Mmbaga et al., 2020; Radu-Lefebvre et al., 2021). According to the discovery theory (Alvarez & Barney, 2007), in fact, the entrepreneur's role lies primarily in identifying opportunities that exist objectively, typically arising from exogenous changes in markets, technologies, or regulation. By contrast, the creation theory holds that opportunities do not pre-exist; they are endogenously brought into being through entrepreneurs' iterative actions, exploring new scenarios, experimenting with methods, and developing novel products and services. From this creation perspective, the centrality of the entrepreneur's personal traits and decision-making capabilities becomes especially salient. The theory of opportunity creation emphasizes the entrepreneur's creativity, their ability to apply their "intelligence to a problem of any nature that leads to a solution that is new compared to the past, based on the available knowledge and the ability to combine forms of divergent and convergent, lateral and vertical, outside and inside the box thinking" (Baccarani 2010). Thus, an objective dimension can be attributed to opportunities while recognizing that they cannot emerge and materialize without the role of certain individuals: the entrepreneurs. Accordingly, as Publius Terentius Afer, argues in his comedy *Heautontimorumenos* (The Self-Punisher, v. 77), as early as 165 BC, stated: "*Homo sum, humani nihil a me alienum puto*" (*I am a man, and everything human concerns me*).

Consistently with this view, being an entrepreneur is a human and professional life experience. Rather than a purely rational utility-maximizer, in fact, the entrepreneur can be seen as an affective, relational agent, *homo oeconomicus* as well as *homo sentimental*, who acts, interacts and constructs meaning through situated practices, processes and contexts (Steyaert, 2007; Gregori, 2024).

*The Tragedy of the Commons* by Garrett Hardin (1968) offers a powerful metaphor for the tension between individual interest and collective well-being. The meadow is very large, but not large enough to accommodate an infinite number of animals. Therefore, each shepherd should refrain from expanding his flock. For the shepherd's individual interest, an additional sheep would mean greater profit, but for the common good, having more animals would mean sooner exhausting the resources that sustain them. Each shepherd, therefore, must necessarily give up a portion of personal gain (in the short term) to protect collective gain (in the long term).

This story brings us back to think about other aspects that can be considered and a necessity of a caring perspective comes out (Andr  & Pache, 2016; Rodriguez et al, 2025; Gallo and Mel , 2025). While traditional entrepreneurship places on the profitable discovery and exploitation of opportunities, the Entrepreneurship of care leans on human dignity and on the social mission, utilizing economic success as a means rather than an end. It emphasizes the value of relationships and dependencies in human life, proposing ethical behaviour based on empathy, compassion, and concern

for the needs of people (Linsley, 2017); it encourages caring relationships among members and develop the capacity to listen to different voices (Andr  and Pache, 2016); moreover, it integrates justice, care, and virtues as contents of a person-centered ethics (Mel ,2024). Within this perspective, some researchers propose also the inclusion of People With Mental Illness and/or Intellectual Disability (PWMI/ID) (Mzembe and Filimonau 2024). Thus, the entrepreneurship of care prioritizes the human need and the person's fulfilment, adapting organizational structures to people rather than people to structures. The mercantile humanism of Benedetto Cotrugli (1458) reminds us that there is no ethical business without people of sound principles. This approach, in fact, has the roots in the ethics of virtues (Aristotle) and it traces harmony back to eudemonia, the "good life" that springs from just and temperate actions, and also values *philautia*, well-ordered self-love, as a condition for loving others. The tradition of *humanitas* (by Terence) insists on dignity, reciprocity, and civil bonds, while the Social doctrine (e.g., Laborem Exercens, Laudato si', Caritas in veritate) and the biblical references (Genesis, Exodus, Gospels) refer to free will, responsibility, and the vocation to put talents at the service of the common good.

According to this perspective, entrepreneurs cannot confine their action to a purely utilitarian view of entrepreneurship. Instead, they place the human being (themselves and all stakeholders) at the centre of entrepreneurial attention, seeking to harmonise and reconcile responsibility toward themselves, people, communities and future generations with business objectives.

## **4.2 From harmony to harmonic**

Entrepreneur as *homo sentimental* works on the "harmonization" of heterogeneous objectives: economics, sociality, or environmental (Coda 2020). In fact, in a world that is volatile, uncertain, complex, and ambiguous, VUCA (Scheibel et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2022), The true challenge of every entrepreneur is to holds different parts together in a coherent whole: this is the essence of Harmony. The term derives from the Greek *harmon  * (        ), which means "joint", "agreement", "good fit". Harmonia, in fact, is the Greek goddess of harmony, and the daughter of Ares (god of war) and Aphrodite (goddess of love and beauty), who tried to put together opposite forces. With Aristotle, harmony meets the ethics of *mes  tes*, the measure that avoids excesses and defects. The Roman world and Stoicism transform harmony into civil bond (*concordia*), while Christian thought brings it back to order and beauty. In the Middle Ages and the Renaissance, harmony guided the arts and sciences: from polyphony to proportional architecture, to Kepler's search for celestial harmonies. Between the modern and contemporary ages, "harmonic" entered into the life and social sciences and harmony became a powerful metaphor for describing complex systems in which autonomous parts cooperate, correct each other, and adapt. Thus, translated into entrepreneurship, harmony means first and

foremost, the capacity to work through and creatively resolve tensions, starting from the tension between profit and value (economic, social, and environmental). In fact, in a changing world characterized by grand societal challenges, rapid technological transformation, and the growing interdependence of economic, social, and ecological systems, it is necessary to integrate individual identity and persona values, with environmental needs and perspectives (Cicione 2023; Passarelli, 2024). Coherently,, "harmony" refers to a way of designing and governing a business that recognizes a plurality of goals and constraints. Thus, inner harmony enables individuals to perceive different opportunities with lucidity and to evaluate them with integrity. Through attentive listening and observation, these opportunities are exploited by orchestrating knowledge, capital, and processes to innovate, while reconciling the pursuit of the new with care for what must be preserved, above all relationships and nature.

#### **4.3 The characteristics of Harmonic Entrepreneur: A Three-Pronged Diamond**

Who is the HEs and what and how they do? In line with the seminal definition (Passarelli, 2024), HE are defined as “three-pronged diamonds”. These individuals are proactive being who, with responsibility, must take care of themselves and what surrounds them, finding a meeting point between individual respect, collective respect, and respect for creation. The three main beliefs that represent harmonic entrepreneurship are: *Salus salutis* (Harmony with oneself that is self-care and personal well-being); *Homo humanitas* (Harmony in relationships that is caring for people and the common good); *Homo humus* (Harmony with creation, with a correct relationship with the goods of the world and the *patermunus*). The Harmonic Entrepreneur lives in harmony with themselves, with others, and with creation.

The care of oneself is an obvious precondition for taking care of the business and people other than oneself. This principle focuses on personal well-being, defined as the individual's physical and psychological health (Shepherd and Patzelt, 2011; Wiklund et al, 2017). The word "health" derives from the Latin “*salus, salutis,*” meaning "safety, soundness, integrity, health," akin to “*salvus*” meaning "safe". The World Health Organization (WHO) has redefined health not merely as the absence of disease, but as "the ability to adapt and self-manage in the face of social, physical, and emotional challenges" (OMS 2011).

Entrepreneurship can be likened to an "emotional roller coaster," involving intense positive feelings (like happiness and fun) and negative feelings (like anger and stress) (Cardon et al. 2012; McEwen 2004 ; Bencsik e Chuluun, 2021). Entrepreneurs are susceptible to stress and often confuse the boundary between their life and the company, perceiving business failures as personal failures. The desire for success and the extreme sense of duty often leads the entrepreneur to "work too much,"

dedicating more hours than other professionals, which impacts physiological and mental balance. Entrepreneurs, in fact, are always under pressure and they must continuously react, to recognize and exploit opportunities. Decisions involve human brain (Waldman et al. 2016) and have connection with some well-known concept in neuroscience (Massaro et al. 2023; Mehta and Josephs 2010; Mehta et al. 2015). In the entrepreneurial literature, there are several studies that analyze the relationship between the neuroscience and their effect on specific entrepreneurial variables (Mehta and Josephs 2010; Mehta et al. 2015), such as: the identification of entrepreneurial opportunities (Nicolau and Shane 2009; 2014) and entrepreneurial alertness (Cucino et al. 2022). Considering these new study perspectives, the results of research analysing the importance of biological factors on entrepreneurship can become a useful tool to help entrepreneurs regain harmony with their body and mind, improving their state of health.

Thus, the seeds of entrepreneurial activity are inevitably tied to the identity and to the sentiments of individual actors and also to the ability to restore harmony and ethics towards oneself. The love of self (*philautia*, according to Aristotle), in fact, is viewed as a sacred duty and a tool for achieving the happiness of the collectively. Thus, the HEs must use their "oxygen mask," adopting a lifestyle that supports self-care, and reduces anxiety and stress, improving the ability to navigate through the entrepreneurial process. Consequently, these principles focus on the capacity to establish genuinely human and fraternal relationships in all spheres of life. Since the entrepreneur is an economic agent, but first and foremost is a social and sentimental actor, when interacting with stakeholders, the entrepreneur must deploy a series of skills that involve the emotional sphere that include: emotional intelligence as a driver for growth and harmonious innovation (Deng et al, 2023); the attitude of kindness and motivation to generate positive relationships (Melo and Anderson, 2016).

This perspective builds on the classical concept of philanthropy, understood as respect for all human beings, and on Cicero's notion of *humanitas* as an objective moral principle. It conceives the entrepreneur as someone who is open to diversity and accustomed to inclusion, actively seeking to valorise the talent and potential of marginalised groups (e.g., persons with disabilities, migrants) (Meng and Kim, 2025). Thus, HE is a builder of positive interpersonal relationships.

Moreover, the Harmonic Entrepreneur promotes the "humanization of science and technologies" (Sanguedolce et al., 2025), that is, a mode of scientific and technological development oriented toward human needs, conducted ethically, and respectful of everyone's rights. In fact, technology should not be an end in itself, but rather a primary enabler of innovation that produces tangible benefits through collaboration between humans and machines. Moreover, the HE supports a model of production and consumption based on sharing, reuse, repair, and recycling, extending the life cycle of products and minimizing waste; this contrasts with the traditional linear economic model ("extract,

produce, use, and discard") (Shepherd and Patzelt, 2017). The HE's commitment to the planet, in fact, aligns with global frameworks like the UN Agenda 2030 and the European Commission's New Green Deal. Having care for creation means following the logic of gratuitousness, love, and service, rather than one of domination. The Harmonic Entrepreneur is an innovator and a careful custodian of creation, respecting nature's rhythms and biodiversity (Vlason, 2021). Since scientific and technological progress must serve the good of all humanity and should not be used in a way that generates inequalities or exploits human and natural resources destructively.

For the HE, opportunities are not seen only as pre-existing "gaps in the market" to be exploited for profit, but as possibilities for enhancing human well-being and dignity. In this sense, opportunities are interpreted and constructed through an anthropocentric lens: they emerge from the recognition of unmet human needs, inequalities and latent capabilities, especially those of marginalized groups, and are evaluated according to their potential to generate both economic value and common good. Thus, the HE engages with opportunities as occasions to humanize technologies, empower people and foster inclusive development, rather than merely as vehicles for financial gain (Sarason et al., 2006). After having outlined the characteristics of harmonic entrepreneurs, we now consider how they actually pass through the entrepreneurial processes.

#### **4.4 An harmonic navigation through the entrepreneurial process**

The Harmonic Entrepreneur adopts Shane and Venkataraman's (2000) view of entrepreneurship as a process of opportunity identification, evaluation and exploitation because it explicitly focuses on a double nexus (individual–opportunity and individual–context) (Dimov, 2002; Shane and Eckhardt, 2003; Fortunato, 2011; Sarason et al., 2016 ; Brown et al, 2024).

In line with this theoretical framework, the Harmonic Entrepreneur is inspired by the interaction of two main drivers: to be well (personal well-being) (Diener, 1984; 1994; Kahneman et al. 1999; Ryff e Singer 2008; Stephan et al. 2023) and to exist well (entrepreneurship of care). (Miles et al. 2004; Harris et al. 2009; Vallaster et al. 2019). Since the concept of the Harmonic Entrepreneur (HE) is anthropocentric, by putting the human person at the core of every entrepreneurial decision, well-being functions as both a design principle and an evaluative standard, structuring how opportunities are discovered, evaluated, and exploited (André & Pache, 2016; Stephan et al., 2023; De Cuyper et al., 2024) by promoting an idiosyncratic, context-embedded individual.

Specifically, in the discovery phase, the concept of "to be well" inspires the balance of mental, physical, and emotional well-being that sustains the clarity, attention, and cognitive openness, needed to recognize entrepreneurial opportunities. Self-care (*philautia*), in fact, supports sustained attention,

listening and observation and the entrepreneur manages the emotional roller coaster, cultivates optimism and passion, and avoids forms of stress or burnout that blur perception. The discovery is led by an ethic of care by an entrepreneur with the attitude to catch opportunities that can “generate good”, not only profit. Through “feeling” and listening to people and communities, the HE recognizes problems where entrepreneurial action can produce positive social and environmental impact (relationships, nature, stakeholders). The discovery of opportunities is also driven by the concept of “to exist well”, that helps to orient perception toward problems whose resolution can generate positive social and environmental impact in the perspective of the entrepreneurship of care.

The evaluation phase is stirred by the impact of opportunities on personal physical and psychological health (workload, stress, lifestyle). In fact, opportunities that structurally compromise inner harmony (e.g. chronic overload, toxic environments) are discarded. During the evaluation phase, the Harmonic Entrepreneur does not limit the analysis to risk–return calculations or competitive positioning. Rather, the assessment of an opportunity is explicitly filtered through ethical and societal lenses. The entrepreneur pauses to ask: “*Will this opportunity contribute to the common good?*”, that is, “*will it enhance people’s well-being, respect their rights, reduce inequalities or empower marginalized groups?*” This question acts as a normative compass that can lead to the redefinition, reshaping or even rejection of opportunities that, although profitable, would generate social or environmental harm. In this way, ethical and societal values do not represent an “add-on” ex post, but become core criteria that structure how opportunities are weighed, prioritised and ultimately pursued. Thus, *Homo-humanitas (relationships)* and *Homo-humus (creation)* are part of the value assessment and financial success must serve a larger purpose and cannot be the sole driver. In the exploitation phase, the HE orchestrates knowledge, capital, and processes not only to capture economic value, but to “make resources available” to others, designing work and leadership practices inspired by empathy, solidarity, legality, and gratitude, and conceiving the enterprise as a communal entity whose financial success must serve a broader purpose. Exploitation is conceived as entrepreneurship of care and the resources are mobilized to enable others to “exist well”. Thus, the exploitation of opportunity goes hand in hand with the growth of people, the quality of work and the care of creation. In this perspective, the enterprise is seen as a communal entity where customers receive fair value, collaborators reach an adequate standard of living, communities benefit from responsible resource use; thus, leadership is inspired by empathy, solidarity, mercy, legality and gratitude.

Across the entrepreneurial process, each step I interpreted not only in economic terms but also in terms of health, happiness, and social impact, that reinforce a virtuous cycle of “being well in order to generate good” through subsequent opportunity discovery, evaluation, and exploitation.



**The HE across the entrepreneurial process (SIPUò ANCHE TOGLIERE)**

| <p align="center"><b>Shane and Venkataraman's (2000)'s entrepreneurial process</b></p> | <p align="center"><b>Harmonic Entrepreneur :<br/>"to be well"<br/>(salus-salutis)</b></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <p align="center"><b>Harmonic Entrepreneur<br/>"to exist well"<br/>(Homo-humanitas and Homo humus)</b></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p align="center"><b>Opportunity discovery</b></p>                                     | <p><i>Harmony (mental, physical, emotional well-being) enables clarity in perceiving "reality" and future scenario to identify opportunities.</i></p> <p><i>The entrepreneur manages the emotional roller coaster, cultivates optimism and passion, and avoids forms of stress or burnout that blur perception.</i></p> <p><i>Self-care (philautìa) supports sustained attention, listening and observation.</i></p> | <p><i>Discovery is guided by an ethic of care: the HE has the posture to catch opportunities that can "generate good", not only profit. Through "feeling" and listening to people and communities, the HE recognizes problems where entrepreneurial action can produce positive social and environmental impact (relationships, nature, stakeholders).</i></p> |
| <p align="center"><b>Opportunity evaluation</b></p>                                    | <p><i>The HE considers the impact on personal physical and psychological health (workload, stress, lifestyle).</i></p> <p><i>Coherence between what one thinks, says and does (eudaimonia) becomes a key evaluation criterion.</i></p>                                                                                                                                                                               | <p><i>Evaluation includes ethical and societal value: "Will this opportunity contribute to the common good?" The HE weighs not only economic outcomes, but also social impact, respect for legality, fairness, and environmental sustainability. Homo-humanitas (relationships) and</i></p>                                                                    |

|                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                 | <i>Opportunities that structurally compromise inner harmony (e.g. chronic overload, toxic environments) are discarded.</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <i>Homo-humus (creation) is part of the value assessment. Financial success must serve a larger purpose and cannot be the sole driver.</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Opportunity exploitation</b> | <p><i>In exploiting the opportunity, the HE orchestrates knowledge, capital and processes in a way that supports both performance and health (mens sana in corpore sano).</i></p> <p><i>They design routines of self-care (movement, exercise, rest, emotional regulation) and a work organization that reduces stress and burnout, fostering positive emotions, creativity, and passion for work.</i></p> | <p><i>Exploitation is conceived as entrepreneurship of care: resources are mobilized to enable others to “exist well”. The enterprise is seen as a communal entity: customers receive fair value, collaborators reach an adequate standard of living, communities benefit from responsible resource use. Leadership is inspired by empathy, solidarity, mercy, legality and gratitude; the HE “exists well” by acting for durable, purpose-aligned results.</i></p> |

Source: Our elaboration

From this analysis comes out a clear nexus between individuals and opportunity, but also the nexus between the individuals and the contexts (Sarason et al., 2006). In summary, harmonic entrepreneurs do not walk a different entrepreneurial process from other entrepreneurs; however, the approach to decision-making across the entrepreneurial process is different, because as human being, attempts to create harmony among heterogeneous factors. For this reason, it is interesting to shift the attention to the analysis of the decisional mechanisms in order to identify the peculiarities of HE across the process.

#### **4.5 Making Harmonic decisions: the emerging role of HE**

The characteristics of the HE are consistent with a view of the entrepreneur as *homo sentimental*, who co-evolves with both opportunities and the contexts in which they are embedded (Illouz, 2007; Shane & Venkataraman, 2000; Sarason et al., 2006; Steyaert, 2007). Accordingly, entrepreneurial decision making emerges from the interplay between this double nexus (individual–opportunity and individual–context) and from the heterogeneity of both individuals and their opportunity–context configurations (Shepherd et al., 2015).

As Shepherd et al. (2015) argue, entrepreneurs differ in their human capital (knowledge, skills, prior experiences), and these differences shape how they search for, interpret and pursue opportunities. They are also heterogeneous in their emotional responses to entrepreneurial opportunities, as well as in how they perceive and interpret environmental conditions, including uncertainty and market dynamics. Such cognitive, emotional and perceptual differences affect which opportunities are recognised as attractive and feasible, how risks and trade-offs are evaluated, and ultimately which entrepreneurial courses of action are chosen. Thus, the entrepreneurial process (Shane & Venkataraman, 2000), is influenced by some decision-specific factors. Within the double nexus (individual–opportunity and individual–context) (Sarason et al., 2006), entrepreneurs often perceive opportunities as mirrors of the self, interpreting them through the lens of their identity and values. Consequently, discovery, evaluation, and exploitation constantly feed back into one another, reshaping both the opportunity set and the entrepreneur. Specifically, what an entrepreneur cares about (values, motives, past experience) tunes what they notice in the environment and the same signal can look like a great or poor opportunity depending on whether it fits one's ethics, purpose, and desired impact. Selecting and enacting an opportunity, reinforces (or revises) who the entrepreneur is trying to be.

The entrepreneur is a reflexive agent engaged in purposeful action; the sources of opportunity are pre-existing features of markets, technologies, and institutions that furnish the context for venture creation and entrepreneurship occurs as agents specify, interpret, and act upon these sources, transforming the opportunity set even as their own beliefs, capabilities, and preferences are reshaped by the interaction. The interactive coming together of entrepreneur and opportunity is conceptualized as a duality whereby the entrepreneur and opportunity cannot exist independently, and therefore, cannot be understood separate and distinct from each other. Thus, each harmonic, human-centered entrepreneur and each opportunity co-evolve through repeated cycles across the entrepreneurial process where, profit is necessary but not sufficient and all the choices must also preserve well-being and generate common-good impact.

Thus, decisions are driven by harmony, coherently with "a spirit of love rich in intelligence," or "a spirit of intelligence filled with love" (Enciclica *Caritas in Veritate*). Therefore, the Harmonic Entrepreneur is someone who, in recognizing, evaluating, and realizing opportunities, integrates personal virtues and technical skills, long-term vision and executive discipline, attention to people, and respect for creation. Their success is not measured only in profits or market share, but in generating trust and social capital, together with the quality of work, care for communities, and regeneration of territories. This is not an abstract appeal to morality, but a concrete proposal. Understood in this way, entrepreneurship returns to being what it can and must be: *a practice of responsible freedom that creates a future on a human scale*. Thus, this is a distinctive approach to entrepreneurial decision making, one that deliberately harmonizes profit with well-being and the common good. In this view, harmony becomes a guiding design and evaluation principle throughout the entire entrepreneurial process (opportunity discovery, evaluation and exploitation) within a co-evolving nexus among individuals, opportunities and contexts.

#### **4.6 Advancing a Harmonic view of Entrepreneurship**

The profile of harmonic entrepreneurs partly overlaps with previous theories, partly open new trajectories of research. The chapter attempted to clarify *who* HEs are (identity and value) with *what* and *how* they do (decisions, actions, relationships) (Steyaert, 2007). The profile of Harmonic Entrepreneur emerges as an evolution of the classical and modern model, in a context of epochal change that requires overcoming the economy based on individual interest, in order to adopt an economy founded on a sense of community and collective well-being. It converges with aspects of prior work yet forges new research paths. Specifically, the conceptual foundation of HE transcends the traditional utilitarian vision of entrepreneurship (Ducker, 1985), by underling the entrepreneurship of care (André and Pache, 2016), and ask for a strong multidisciplinary convergence (Matricano, 2023; Passarelli, 2024). For the HE, profit is merely one of multiple objectives (competitive, economic-financial, social, and environmental) that must be harmonized. In fact, profit sought is distinguished by *how* it is pursued (based on efficiency and humanity) and *how* it is employed, favouring the long-term functionality and development of the enterprise. This approach does not pit ethics against business; rather, it advances a harmonic dialogue in which values are translated into strategic criteria, engaging all human dimensions and multiple social aspects. In doing so, it calls for a robust interdisciplinary conversation among heterogeneous, to inform and enrich entrepreneurial decision making. In fact, economics and management offer tools for leading entrepreneurial processes and organising means and resources (Drucker, 1985; Shane, 2000); psychology and neuroscience help us understand cognition, emotions, stress, passion, and motivations (Nicolaou et

al, 2009; Nicolaou and Shane, 2014; Krueger and Welppe, 2014; Metha et al., 2015; Melo and Anderson, 2016; Nofal et al, 2018; Nofal and Nicolaou, 2021); philosophy and ethics help to clarify the meaning of action (Miles et al, 2004; Toledano, 2022; Passarelli et al., 2025); environmental sciences remind us of planetary limits and intergenerational responsibility (De Groot and Steg, 2008; Youssef et al., 2018). A harmonic view of entrepreneurship invites a rich research agenda that is simultaneously theoretical, empirical and normative, calling scholars to rethink what it means to create value “for” and “with” human being.

The harmonic profile is not an idealized blueprint but a viable orientation for engaging human and social complexity. However, the first step is to acknowledge it and commit to moving in that direction.

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